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Queen's Gambit Declined Main Systems

Orthodox, Lasker, Tartakower, Cambridge Springs, and Harrwitz plans

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

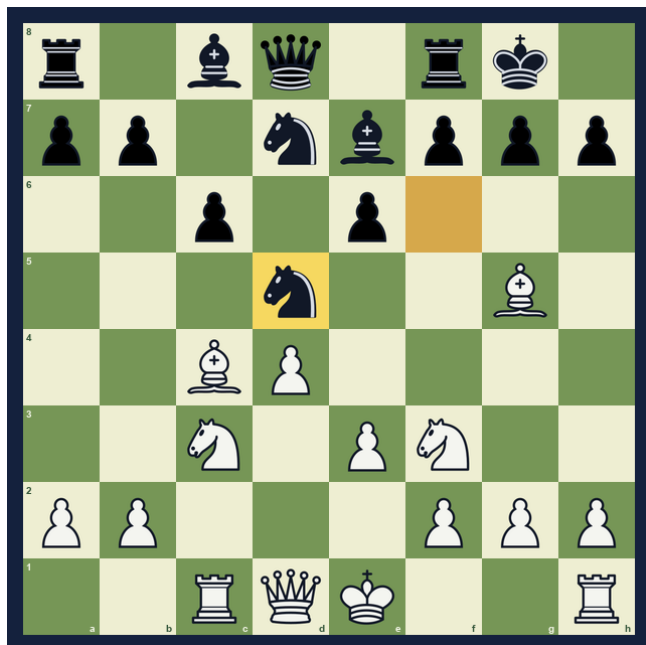
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
QGD MAIN SYSTEMS	20

01. QGD Orthodox Main Line



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use pieces to keep Black's center tied down.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black offers exchanges to relieve space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

01. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.
PIECE JOB	White's c1-rook, active c4-bishop and central knights should make Black's cramped pieces pay before exchanges free them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange active pieces merely because the position is closed; each trade can release Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Maintain pressure, provoke a concession, and enter the endgame only when a fixed pawn weakness survives the exchanges. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.

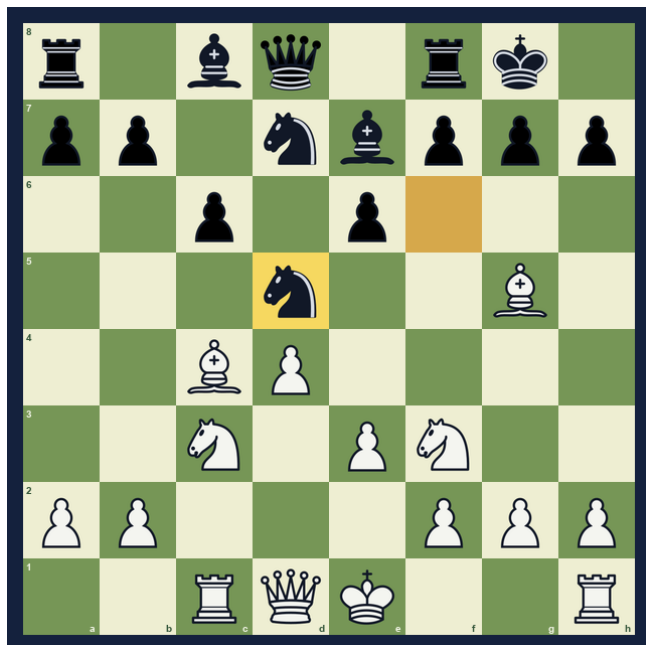
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

02. QGD Orthodox Main Line



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use pieces to keep Black's center tied down.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black offers exchanges to relieve space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

02. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line

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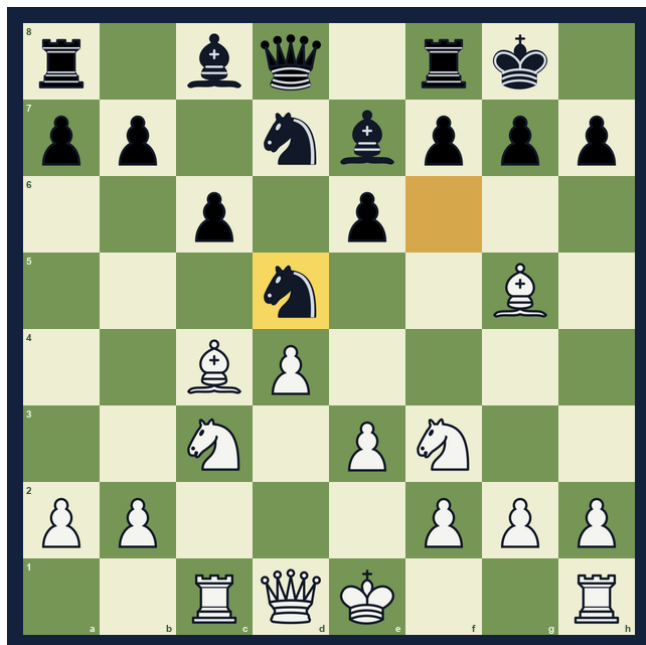
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03. QGD Orthodox Main Line



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

PRIMARY PLAN

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REFERENCE LINE

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MEMORY RULE

Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

03. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line

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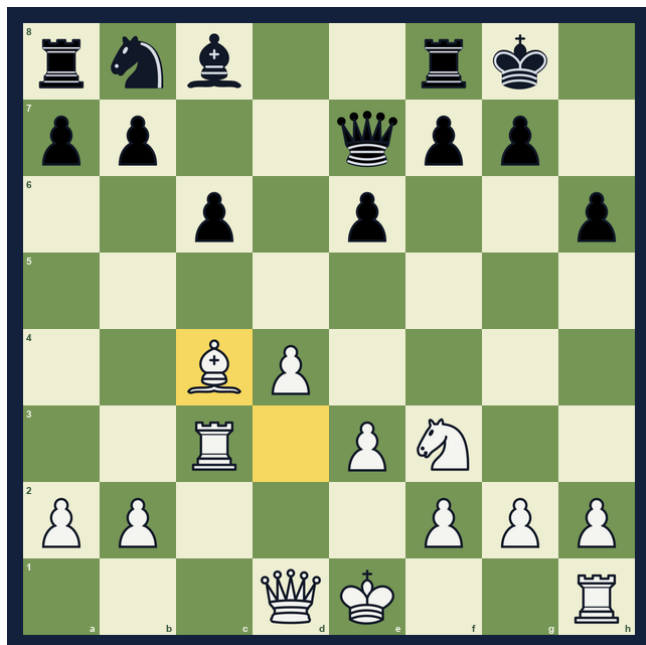
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

04. QGD Lasker Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the c-file and active bishops after exchanges.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black begins the simplifying operation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

04. Decision Framework

QGD Lasker Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.
PIECE JOB	After Black's ...Ne4 exchanges, White's remaining pieces must occupy the open c- and e-files quickly.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not cooperate with every simplification.
TRADE FILTER	Accept simplification when it leaves a queenside weakness or superior minor piece; otherwise preserve tension and space.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Rebuild pressure after the forced trades by centralizing rooks and improving the least active remaining piece. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not cooperate with every simplification.

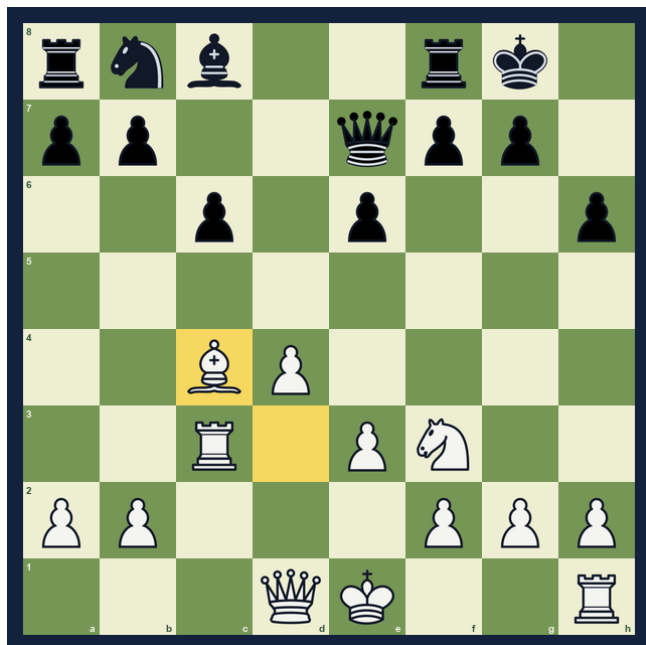
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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05. QGD Lasker Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

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MEMORY RULE

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05. Decision Framework

QGD Lasker Defense

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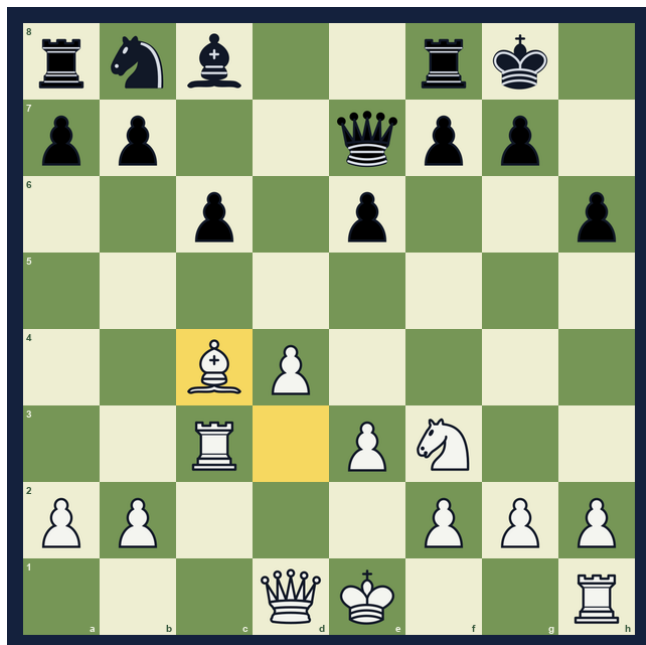
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

06. QGD Lasker Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the c-file and active bishops after exchanges.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black begins the simplifying operation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

06. Decision Framework

QGD Lasker Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

07. QGD Tartakower Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.

PRIMARY PLAN

Pressure c7 and queenside entry squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b6-Bb7: Black activates the previously bad bishop.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

07. Decision Framework

QGD Tartakower Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.
PIECE JOB	White should pressure the queenside dark squares while preventing Black's b7-bishop from becoming completely free.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not mistake a diagonal for a complete attack.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active bishop when that leaves exploitable light-square or queenside weaknesses, not merely to simplify.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Convert small space and structural edges by restricting the hanging pawns, then attacking them after their activity fades. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not mistake a diagonal for a complete attack.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

08. QGD Tartakower Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.

PRIMARY PLAN

Pressure c7 and queenside entry squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b6-Bb7: Black activates the previously bad bishop.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

08. Decision Framework

QGD Tartakower Defense

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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

09. QGD Tartakower Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.

PRIMARY PLAN

Pressure c7 and queenside entry squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b6-Bb7: Black activates the previously bad bishop.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

09. Decision Framework

QGD Tartakower Defense

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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

10. Cambridge Springs Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nd2 and Qc2 to remove tactical pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qa5: Black creates the Cambridge Springs pin and pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Nbd7 5. e3 c6 6. Nf3 Qa5 7. Nd2 Bb4 8. Qc2 O-O 9. Be2 dxc4 10. Bxf6 Nxf6 11. Nxc4 Qc7 12. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

10. Decision Framework

Cambridge Springs Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.
PIECE JOB	Nd2, Qc2 and Be2 form a safety net that unpins the queenside before White tries to recover c4.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.
TRADE FILTER	Bxf6 is useful when it removes a tactical defender and permits Nxc4; the order matters more than the desire to keep bishops.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Neutralize the pins, recover the pawn with a developed piece, castle, and only then look for an advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

11. Cambridge Springs Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nd2 and Qc2 to remove tactical pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qa5: Black creates the Cambridge Springs pin and pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

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MEMORY RULE

Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

11. Decision Framework

Cambridge Springs Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.
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ENDGAME FORECAST	Neutralize the pins, recover the pawn with a developed piece, castle, and only then look for an advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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12. Cambridge Springs Defense



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nd2 and Qc2 to remove tactical pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qa5: Black creates the Cambridge Springs pin and pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

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MEMORY RULE

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12. Decision Framework

Cambridge Springs Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.
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TACTICAL WARNING	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.
TRADE FILTER	Bxf6 is useful when it removes a tactical defender and permits Nxc4; the order matters more than the desire to keep bishops.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Neutralize the pins, recover the pawn with a developed piece, castle, and only then look for an advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.

ACTIVE RECALL

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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

13. QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete Qc2, Rd1, and a3 with pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges d4 and seeks equality.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

MEMORY RULE

Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

13. Decision Framework

QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.
PIECE JOB	The f4-bishop controls e5 and helps White develop pressure without committing to the traditional Bg5 pin.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the f4-bishop only when the remaining structure or open file compensates for losing its central influence.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use Qc2, Rd1 and a3 to finish development, then turn control of e5 and the d-file into concrete pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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14. QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

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PRIMARY PLAN

Complete Qc2, Rd1, and a3 with pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges d4 and seeks equality.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

MEMORY RULE

Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

14. Decision Framework

QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.
PIECE JOB	The f4-bishop controls e5 and helps White develop pressure without committing to the traditional Bg5 pin.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the f4-bishop only when the remaining structure or open file compensates for losing its central influence.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use Qc2, Rd1 and a3 to finish development, then turn control of e5 and the d-file into concrete pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

15. QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete Qc2, Rd1, and a3 with pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges d4 and seeks equality.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

MEMORY RULE

Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

15. Decision Framework

QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.
PIECE JOB	The f4-bishop controls e5 and helps White develop pressure without committing to the traditional Bg5 pin.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.
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CLOCK RULE	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.

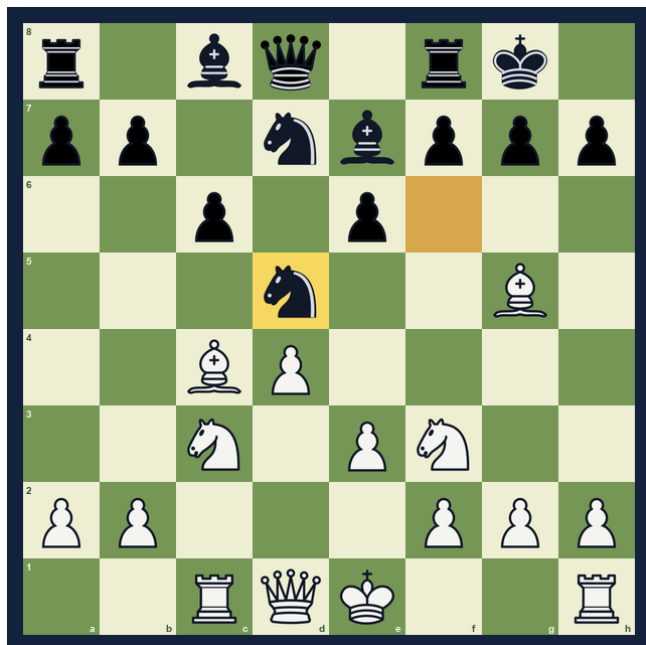
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

16. QGD Orthodox Main Line - Move-Order Lab



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

PRIMARY PLAN

Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black offers exchanges to relieve space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

16. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.
PIECE JOB	White's c1-rook, active c4-bishop and central knights should make Black's cramped pieces pay before exchanges free them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange active pieces merely because the position is closed; each trade can release Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Maintain pressure, provoke a concession, and enter the endgame only when a fixed pawn weakness survives the exchanges. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.

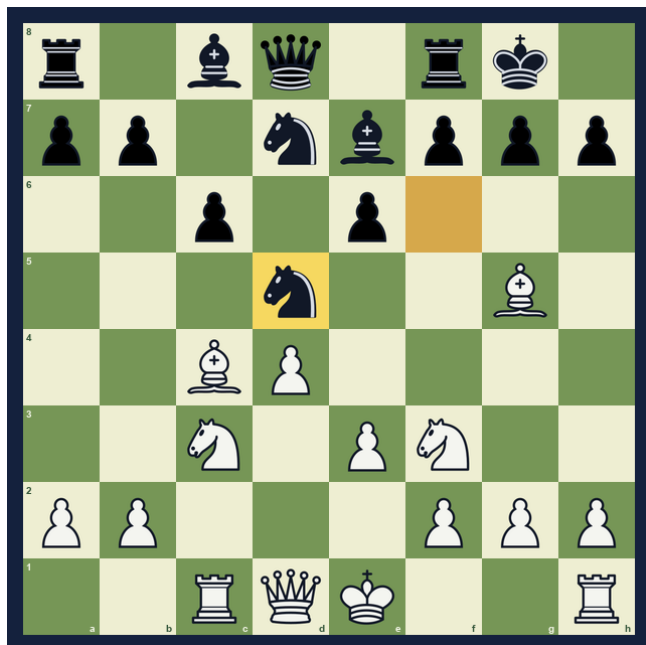
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

17. QGD Orthodox Main Line - Plan Lab



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Use pieces to keep Black's center tied down.

PRIMARY PLAN

White's c1-rook, active c4-bishop and central knights should make Black's cramped pieces pay before exchanges free them.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black offers exchanges to relieve space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

17. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.
PIECE JOB	White's c1-rook, active c4-bishop and central knights should make Black's cramped pieces pay before exchanges free them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange active pieces merely because the position is closed; each trade can release Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Maintain pressure, provoke a concession, and enter the endgame only when a fixed pawn weakness survives the exchanges. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.

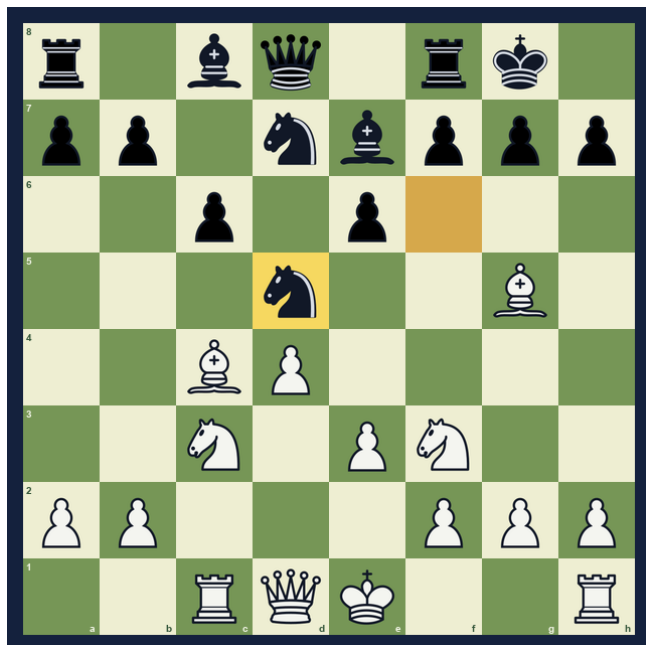
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

18. QGD Orthodox Main Line - Break Lab



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black offers exchanges to relieve space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

18. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.
PIECE JOB	White's c1-rook, active c4-bishop and central knights should make Black's cramped pieces pay before exchanges free them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange active pieces merely because the position is closed; each trade can release Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Maintain pressure, provoke a concession, and enter the endgame only when a fixed pawn weakness survives the exchanges. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.

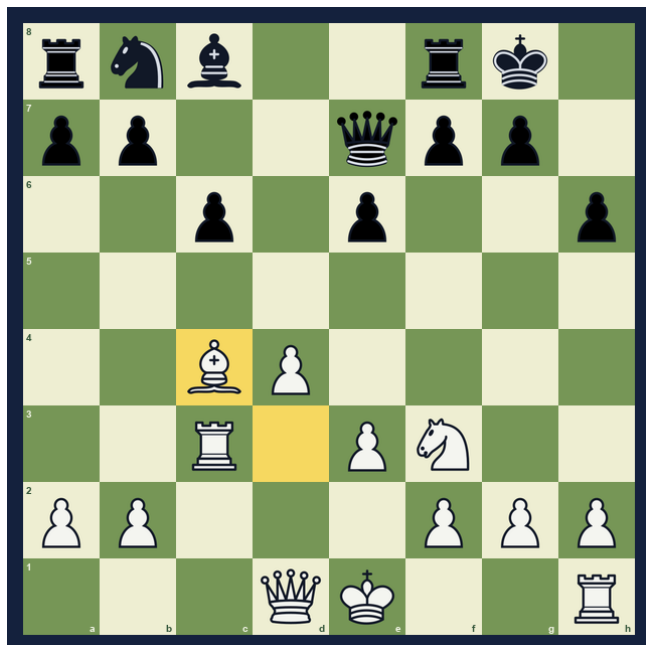
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

19. QGD Lasker Defense - Trade Lab



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Accept simplification when it leaves a queenside weakness or superior minor piece; otherwise preserve tension and space.

PRIMARY PLAN

Rebuild pressure after the forced trades by centralizing rooks and improving the least active remaining piece. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black begins the simplifying operation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

19. Decision Framework

QGD Lasker Defense - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.
PIECE JOB	After Black's ...Ne4 exchanges, White's remaining pieces must occupy the open c- and e-files quickly.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not cooperate with every simplification.
TRADE FILTER	Accept simplification when it leaves a queenside weakness or superior minor piece; otherwise preserve tension and space.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Rebuild pressure after the forced trades by centralizing rooks and improving the least active remaining piece. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not cooperate with every simplification.

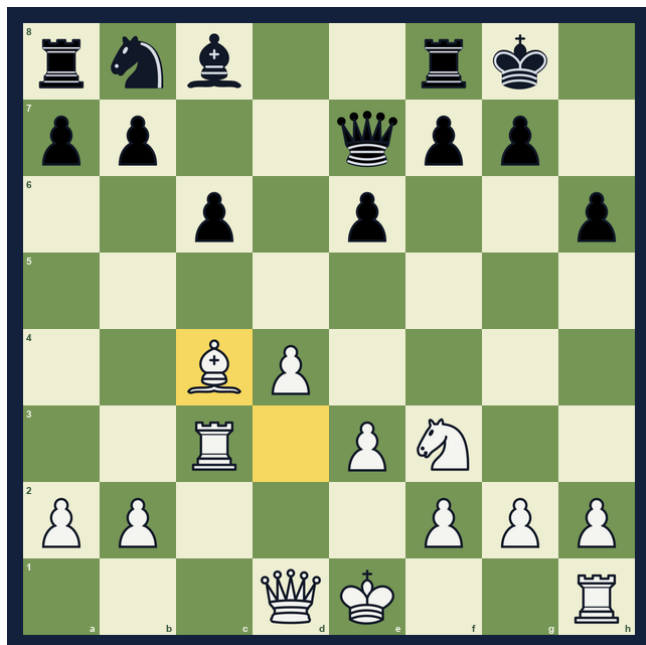
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

20. QGD Lasker Defense - Move-Order Lab



QGD MAIN SYSTEMS

READ THE POSITION

Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.

PRIMARY PLAN

Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black begins the simplifying operation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

20. Decision Framework

QGD Lasker Defense - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.
PIECE JOB	After Black's ...Ne4 exchanges, White's remaining pieces must occupy the open c- and e-files quickly.
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CLOCK RULE	Do not cooperate with every simplification.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.